10.3. Four principles for effective process

The next group of four principles answers the question “Is your process effective?”

- ***Simplicity*** —The art of maximizing the amount of work not done is essential.
- *Deliver working software frequently*, from a couple of weeks to a couple of months, with a preference to the shorter timescale.
- ***Face-to-face conversation*** —The most efficient and effective method of conveying information to and within a development team.
- *Maintain a constant pace* indefinitely—Agile processes promote sustainable development. The sponsors, developers, and users should be able to maintain a constant pace indefinitely.

As a software engineer, my initial reaction to simplicity was that it related to software measurement. After all, you should use simple designs and standard patterns to maximize efficiency on your development team and increase the maintainability of your software. Although maximizing the amount of work done relates to maintainable code, simplicity is most easily measured by looking at data from your PTS, such as task volume or the number of tasks completed. Maximizing the amount of work done implies an effective process: understanding the minimum of what needs to get done in order to improve your consumer’s experience.

Delivering working software frequently is easily measured by the amount of time it takes to get tasks through the lifecycle and out to consumers. One caution for measuring the delivery of working software is to measure the time it takes to get working software to the consumer, not to the end of a development cycle if that doesn’t include deployments. I’ve seen teams celebrate the fact that their development time was very short, even though they did gigantic monthly releases to their consumers. Be honest with your delivery time.

Face-to-face conversation is great, but I’ve been in plenty of meetings or planning sessions where what is said ends up getting interpreted differently by different people in the room. The real key to this principle is ensuring